

Financing New Ventures: Startup Status and Loan Terms in the U.S. SBA 7(a) Program

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Data: U.S. Small Business Administration 7(a) FOIA loan-level records, FY2010-FY2025

Abstract

This study examines how loan amounts and initial interest rates differ between startup and established-business borrowers within the U.S. Small Business Administration (SBA) 7(a) program. Using loan-level administrative data covering fiscal years 2010-2025, the analysis identifies startups using the SBA classification “Startup, Loan Funds will Open Business” and compares them with borrowers in clearly established business-age categories. The resulting analytical sample contains 681,992 approved loans, including 138,054 startup loans and 543,938 established-business loans. Descriptively, startup loans have higher mean and median approval amounts but slightly lower initial interest rates. In regressions controlling for fiscal year, project jurisdiction, and two-digit NAICS industry, startup status is associated with approximately 18.0% higher gross approval amounts. After additionally accounting for processing method, business type, and collateral status, the estimated association reverses to approximately 13.7% lower approval amounts. Startup status is also associated with initial interest rates that are 0.205 percentage points lower in the baseline specification and 0.105 percentage points lower in the extended specification. Results remain similar in direction under alternative clustering and a stricter established-business definition. The findings show that observed differences in financing terms between startup and established borrowers within the SBA 7(a) program are sensitive to borrower, program, and loan composition. Because the data contain approved loans only, the estimates represent conditional associations and do not identify causal effects or differences in the probability of obtaining credit.

Keywords: entrepreneurial finance; startup financing; SBA 7(a); small-business lending; loan pricing; government loan guarantees

JEL classifications: G21; G28; L26

1. Introduction

Financing is a central challenge in the creation and development of new firms. Young businesses generally have shorter operating histories, less established financial information, and fewer observable signals of repayment capacity than mature firms. These characteristics can increase information problems between entrepreneurs and external financiers and shape both the types of financing available and the terms on which financing is provided. Financial life-cycle theory consequently emphasizes firm age and size as important dimensions of financing structure (Berger & Udell, 1998).

Startup financing, however, is not determined by firm age alone. Asset structure, organizational form, lender relationships, lending technology, collateral, and institutional arrangements can also affect how financing is structured. Cassar (2004), for example, finds that startup size, asset structure, organizational form, and growth orientation are associated with financing choices around business formation. Berger and Udell (2006) further emphasize the importance of lending technologies and financial institutions in understanding small-business credit.

Government-guaranteed lending provides a useful institutional setting in which to examine these relationships. The SBA describes 7(a) as its primary business loan program. Participating lenders make loans under program rules, while the SBA guarantees a portion of eligible loans. The

program can support working capital, equipment, real estate, refinancing, and changes of ownership (U.S. Small Business Administration, 2026a).

Prior research demonstrates that SBA lending is relevant to small-business finance and firm outcomes. Craig, Jackson, and Thomson (2007) examine SBA-guaranteed lending and local economic growth. Brown and Earle (2017), using linked SBA, lender, and U.S. employer data, estimate effects of financial access on employment growth and report stronger estimated impacts for younger firms in their setting. Hackney (2023) studies government-guaranteed lending during the 2007-2009 financial crisis and finds that areas with greater SBA 7(a) lender presence experienced higher small-business loan volume and other economic differences during the crisis.

Research has also examined startups specifically within SBA lending. Kang (2017), using 683 SBA 7(a) loan activities involving information-technology-based startups, studies soft information and lender characteristics in high-tech startup debt financing. The present paper therefore does not claim to be the first study of startups using SBA loan data. Instead, it provides a broad comparison of observed loan amounts and initial interest rates between startup and established borrowers across a large, multi-industry sample of approved SBA 7(a) loans.

Recent evidence also suggests that the relationship between firm age and loan pricing may be more complicated than a simple prediction that younger firms always face higher rates. Cowling, Mac an Bhaird, O'Reilly, and Yang (2026), using UK loan-contract data, report that new firms within size classes can receive lower interest-rate offers than early-stage firms, despite broader information-based predictions of financial life-cycle theory.

Research question. How do loan amounts and initial interest rates differ between startup and established-business borrowers within the SBA 7(a) program, and how sensitive are these differences to observable industry, geographic, program, and loan characteristics?

The analysis combines SBA 7(a) administrative data covering FY2010-FY2025. The analytical sample contains 681,992 approved loans, of which 138,054 are classified as startups and 543,938 as established businesses. The analysis begins with descriptive comparisons and then estimates regression models incorporating fiscal-year, project-jurisdiction, industry, program, borrower, and loan characteristics.

Three findings stand out. First, startups have larger loan amounts in the unadjusted data: the median approved amount is \$200,000 for startups compared with \$150,000 for established businesses. Second, the estimated loan-amount relationship is highly sensitive to model specification. Startup status is associated with approximately 18.0% higher approval amounts in the baseline model but approximately 13.7% lower amounts after observable program and borrower characteristics are added. Third, startups have slightly lower initial interest rates in both the baseline and extended specifications, although the magnitude decreases after additional controls are introduced.

These results do not establish whether startups have better or worse access to credit. The data contain approved SBA 7(a) loans rather than the complete population of businesses seeking financing. The analysis therefore describes financing terms conditional on observed approved SBA 7(a) loans.

2. Literature Review and Conceptual Background

2.1 Financial life-cycle theory and startup finance

Berger and Udell (1998) develop a financial-growth-cycle perspective in which financing sources and structures vary with firm size, age, and informational characteristics. Younger and smaller firms tend to be more informationally opaque because they possess shorter histories and less publicly observable information. As firms develop, their financing possibilities may change alongside their information environment and organizational characteristics.

Berger and Udell (2006) broaden this perspective by emphasizing lending technologies and institutional structures. Their framework highlights that SME financing cannot be understood solely from borrower characteristics; the technologies lenders use to originate and monitor credit and the financial environment in which lenders operate also matter.

Cassar (2004) provides direct evidence concerning financing around business formation. The study examines how startup size, asset structure, organizational type, growth orientation, and owner characteristics relate to financing choices and financing magnitudes. The findings are consistent with the relevance of information asymmetry, agency considerations, and transaction costs in startup financing.

These perspectives imply that differences between startup and established borrowers may reflect more than business age itself. Loan size and pricing may also vary with industry, location, collateral, organizational form, lender practices, and program structure.

2.2 Government-guaranteed small-business lending

The SBA 7(a) program introduces another institutional layer into the financing relationship. SBA states that 7(a) is its primary business loan program and that borrowers apply through participating lenders rather than directly to SBA. Specific terms are negotiated between the borrower and participating lender subject to SBA requirements (U.S. Small Business Administration, 2026a).

This institutional structure matters for empirical interpretation. Financing outcomes observed in 7(a) data reflect both borrower characteristics and the structure of a government-guaranteed lending program. Consequently, patterns observed within the program should not automatically be generalized to conventional bank credit or entrepreneurial financing as a whole.

Prior studies show the relevance of SBA lending for broader firm outcomes. Brown and Earle (2017) analyze linked SBA, lender, and U.S. employer data and estimate positive employment effects associated with financial access in their research design. Hackney (2023) studies government-guaranteed lending during a financial crisis and reports that areas with greater SBA 7(a) lender presence experienced higher small-business loan volume and other economic differences during the 2007-2009 crisis.

Kang (2017) provides a particularly relevant entrepreneurial-finance connection. Using 683 SBA 7(a) loan activities involving information-technology-based startups, the study examines soft information and reports relationships between default outcomes, geographic proximity to lenders, and lender size. This supports the broader proposition that lender and information characteristics may matter when analyzing startup debt financing.

2.3 Firm age and interest-rate setting

A simple information-asymmetry argument could suggest that young firms should face higher borrowing costs. Recent research, however, indicates that observed pricing patterns need not be monotonic with firm age.

Cowling et al. (2026) explicitly examine whether financial life-cycle theory extends to loan interest-rate setting. Using 31,760 UK loan contracts issued under the Recovery Loan Scheme from April 2021 through May 2024, they find substantial variation across the firm size-age continuum and report that new firms within size classes tend to receive lower interest-rate offers than early-stage firms. Their setting and identification differ from the present study, but the finding is relevant to interpreting a negative startup-rate association without assuming a simple monotonic age-pricing relationship.

The current analysis does not test a specific lender-pricing mechanism. Instead, it asks whether startup and established SBA borrowers exhibit different observed initial rates and whether those differences remain after conditioning on measurable loan and program characteristics.

3. Data and Sample

This study uses loan-level administrative data from the U.S. Small Business Administration 7(a) program. The analysis combines the SBA 7(a) FOIA datasets covering fiscal years 2010-2019 and 2020-present. The SBA open-data portal states that the 7(a) and 504 FOIA files are updated quarterly and provides a data dictionary for the files (U.S. Small Business Administration, 2026b). Because the latter file used for this study was available only through June 30, 2026, FY2026 is excluded to avoid treating an incomplete fiscal year as comparable with complete years. The primary study period therefore covers FY2010-FY2025.

The combined data contain information on gross approval amounts, initial interest rates, loan terms, borrower location, industry, business age, processing method, business type, collateral status, lender, and other loan characteristics. After restricting the data to complete fiscal years from 2010 through 2025, 893,265 records remained before applying the business-age classification.

The primary analysis distinguishes startups from established businesses using the SBA BusinessAge field. A startup is defined specifically as a borrower classified as “Startup, Loan Funds will Open Business.” This definition is used because the exact category appears in both source periods.

The established-business group consists of observations classified as “Existing or more than 2 years old,” “Existing, 5 or more years,” “Less than 3 years old but at least 2,” “Less than 4 years old but at least 3,” or “Less than 5 years old but at least 4.” Change-of-ownership observations, unanswered or missing business-age records, and other new-business categories whose definitions differ across reporting periods are excluded from the primary comparison.

Applying these criteria produces an analytical sample of 681,992 approved loans: 138,054 startup loans and 543,938 established-business loans. Startups therefore represent approximately 20.2% of the analytical sample.

4. Variables and Empirical Strategy

4.1 Outcomes and explanatory variable

The analysis considers two primary financing outcomes: gross approval amount and initial interest rate. Gross approval amounts are strongly right-skewed, so regression models use the natural logarithm of GrossApproval. Coefficients on startup status in log-loan models are converted to percentage differences using $100 \times [\exp(\beta) - 1]$.

Initial interest rates are analyzed in percentage-point units. Observations with missing or zero reported initial interest rates are excluded from interest-rate models. Zero reported loan terms are excluded when term information is required. The primary explanatory variable, StartupBinary, equals one for borrowers meeting the startup definition and zero for borrowers in the established-business comparison group.

4.2 Regression specifications and inference

For loan amounts, the baseline specification regresses log gross approval amount on startup status with fiscal-year, project-jurisdiction, and two-digit NAICS industry fixed effects. The extended loan specification additionally includes SBA processing method, business type, and collateral status.

For interest rates, the baseline model contains the same fiscal-year, jurisdiction, and industry fixed effects. The extended interest-rate specification additionally includes log gross approval amount, loan term, fixed-versus-variable interest-rate status, processing method, business type, and collateral status.

Standard errors in the primary models are clustered by lender, using lender name because it is nearly complete in the analytical data. As a robustness exercise, standard errors are alternatively clustered by project jurisdiction. The analytical data contain 56 project-state/jurisdiction categories; this should not be interpreted as 56 U.S. states.

These regressions are observational. The coefficient on startup status is therefore interpreted as a conditional association, not as a causal effect of being a startup.

5. Results

5.1 Descriptive evidence

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics by Firm Stage

Measure	Established	Startup
N	543,938	138,054
Mean gross approval	\$399,458	\$462,802
Median gross approval	\$150,000	\$200,000
Mean initial interest rate	7.30%	7.14%
Median initial interest rate	6.50%	6.25%
Mean term (months)	126	131
Median term (months)	120	120
Collateralized	73.6%	90.1%
Fixed rate	18.9%	20.0%
Corporation	88.5%	92.7%

Note. Sample consists of approved SBA 7(a) loans in FY2010-FY2025 retained under the primary startup-versus-established business-age definition. Zero reported initial interest rates are excluded from rate summaries; zero reported terms are excluded from term summaries.

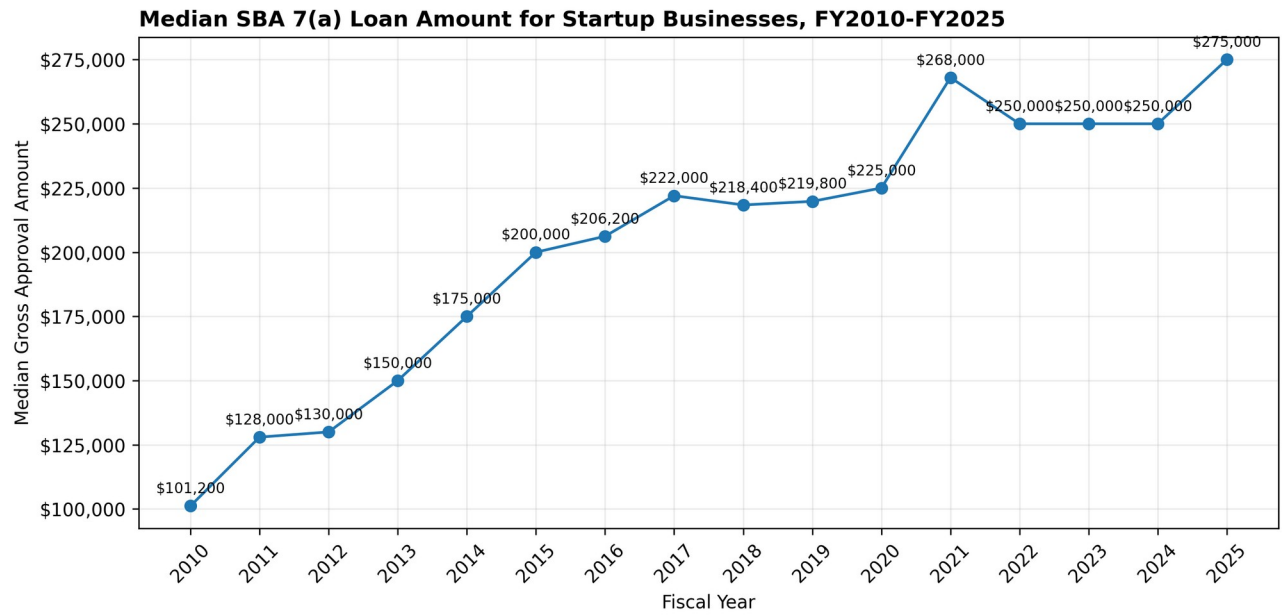
The analytical sample contains 681,992 SBA 7(a) loans, including 138,054 startup loans and 543,938 established-business loans. Startup loans have a mean gross approval amount of \$462,802 and a median of \$200,000, compared with \$399,458 and \$150,000, respectively, for established businesses.

The loan distributions are right-skewed. At the 75th percentile, startup approval amounts are \$475,000 compared with \$382,700 among established borrowers. At the 90th percentile, the respective values are \$1.130 million and \$1.062 million.

Initial interest rates are slightly lower for startups in the raw data. The startup mean is 7.14%, compared with 7.30% for established businesses, while the medians are 6.25% and 6.50%, respectively. Both groups have a median loan term of 120 months, although mean terms are approximately 131 months for startups and 126 months for established businesses.

Other financing characteristics differ more substantially. Approximately 90.1% of startup observations are identified as collateralized compared with 73.6% of established-business observations. Fixed-rate loans constitute approximately 20.0% and 18.9%, respectively. Corporations account for 92.7% of startup borrowers and 88.5% of established borrowers.

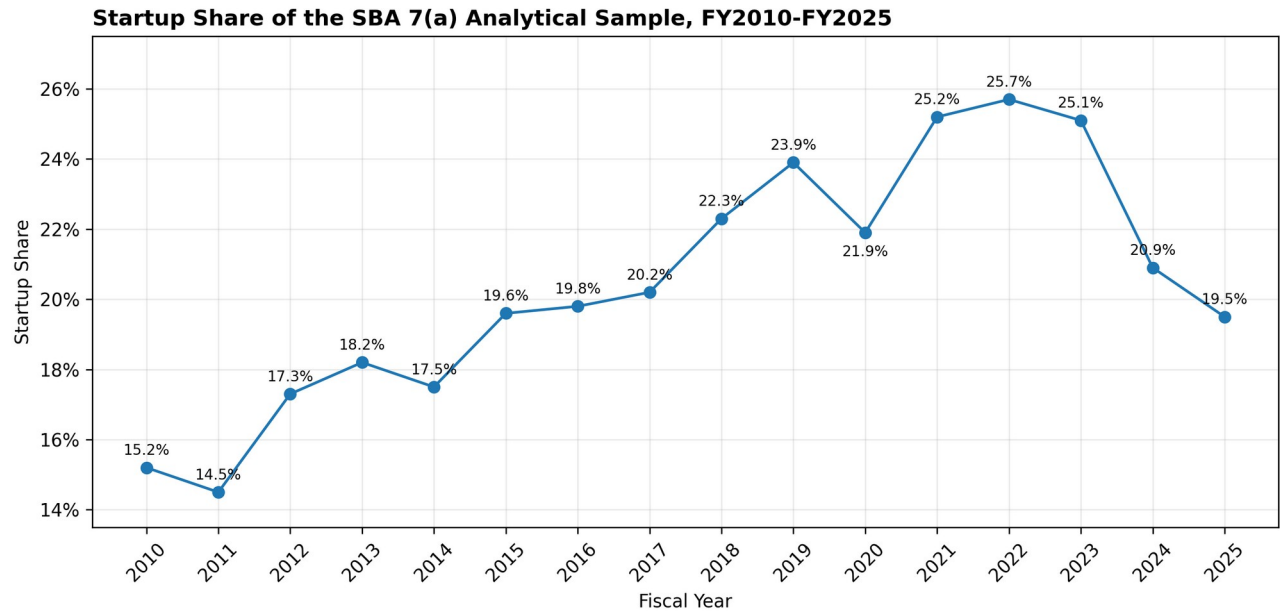
Startup defined as 'Startup, Loan Funds will Open Business'



Source: U.S. Small Business Administration 7(a) FOIA data. Author's calculations.

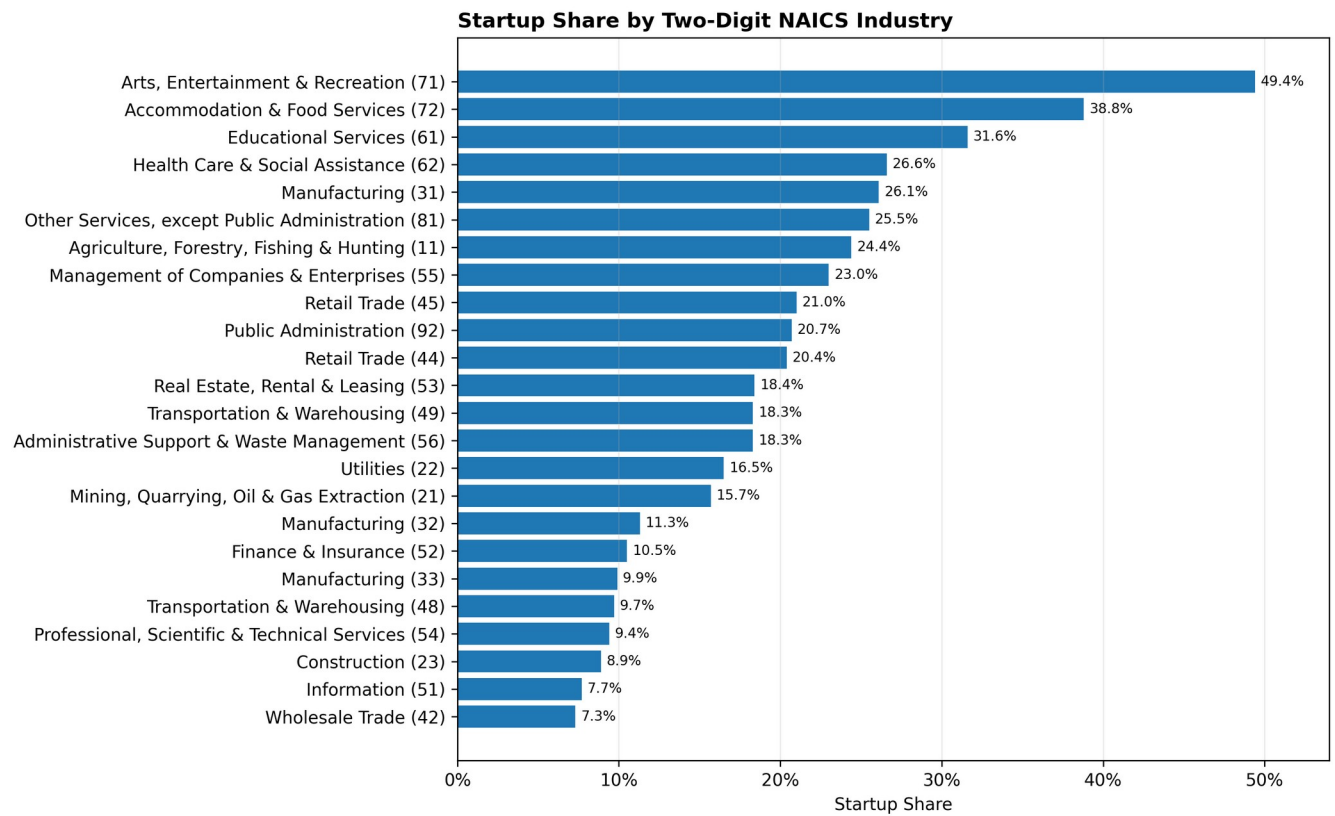
Figure 1. Median SBA 7(a) Loan Amount for Startup Businesses, FY2010-FY2025. Values are nominal and are not adjusted for inflation.

Startup loans as a percentage of startup and established-business loans in the analytical sample



Source: U.S. Small Business Administration 7(a) FOIA data. Author's calculations.

Figure 2. Startup Share of the SBA 7(a) Analytical Sample, FY2010-FY2025. Startup share is calculated among observations classified as either startup or established businesses under the study's primary business-age definition; it is not the startup share of all SBA 7(a) loans.



Source: U.S. Small Business Administration 7(a) FOIA data. Author's calculations.

Figure 3. Startup Share by Two-Digit NAICS Industry. Startup share is calculated as startup loans divided by the combined number of startup and established-business loans within each observed two-digit NAICS category in the analytical sample, FY2010-FY2025.

Figure 1 shows that the nominal median approval amount among startup borrowers increased from \$101,200 in FY2010 to \$275,000 in FY2025, a nominal increase of approximately 171.7%. The pattern is not monotonic, and the figure is not adjusted for inflation; it therefore should not be interpreted as an equivalent increase in real purchasing power.

Figure 2 shows changes in startup representation within the analytical sample. The share was 15.2% in FY2010, reached 25.7% in FY2022, and declined to 19.5% in FY2025. These percentages refer only to observations retained in the startup-versus-established analytical sample.

Startup representation also differs considerably by industry. Figure 3 shows startup shares ranging from 49.4% in NAICS 71 (Arts, Entertainment and Recreation) and 38.8% in NAICS 72 (Accommodation and Food Services) to 7.7% in Information (51) and 7.3% in Wholesale Trade (42). This compositional variation motivates the inclusion of industry controls in the regression analysis.

5.2 Loan-amount and interest-rate regressions

Table 2. Startup Status and SBA 7(a) Loan Terms

	Loan Amount Baseline	Loan Amount Extended	Initial Rate Baseline	Initial Rate Extended
Startup coefficient	0.1658	-0.1478	-0.2053	-0.1046
Lender-clustered SE	(0.0709)	(0.0512)	(0.0819)	(0.0407)
p-value	0.019	0.004	0.012	0.010
Implied loan difference	+18.04%	-13.74%	—	—
Fiscal-year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Project-jurisdiction FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Two-digit NAICS FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Additional controls	No	Yes	No	Yes
N	681,990	681,956	681,915	681,881

Note. Columns 1-2 use the natural log of gross approval amount as the dependent variable; percentage differences are calculated as $100 \times [\exp(\beta) - 1]$. Columns 3-4 use initial interest rate in percentage points. Baseline models include fiscal-year, project-jurisdiction, and two-digit NAICS fixed effects. The extended loan model additionally includes processing method, business type, and collateral status. The extended rate model additionally includes log gross approval, loan term, fixed-versus-variable rate status, processing method, business type, and collateral status. Standard errors are clustered by lender. Estimates are conditional associations among approved SBA 7(a) loans.

The baseline loan-amount model produces a startup coefficient of 0.1658, with a lender-clustered standard error of 0.0709 and $p = 0.019$. Transforming the log coefficient implies an estimated difference of approximately 18.04% in gross approval amounts between startup and established-business loans, conditional on the baseline controls.

The relationship changes substantially in the extended specification. After adding processing method, business type, and collateral status, the startup coefficient becomes -0.1478 (clustered SE = 0.0512; $p = 0.004$), corresponding to approximately 13.74% lower gross approval amounts for startups conditional on the extended set of observed characteristics.

This sign reversal is a central result. It indicates that the estimated startup-loan-size relationship is highly sensitive to observable financing and program composition. The baseline and extended models answer different conditional questions, and the extended specification should not be interpreted as identifying a causal startup effect.

For initial interest rates, the baseline model produces a startup coefficient of -0.2053 percentage points (lender-clustered SE = 0.0819; $p = 0.012$). In the extended specification, after additionally accounting for loan amount, loan term, fixed-versus-variable rate status, processing method, business type, and collateral status, the startup coefficient is -0.1046 percentage points (clustered SE = 0.0407; $p = 0.010$).

The negative startup-interest-rate association therefore remains in both specifications, but its magnitude is approximately halved after the additional observable characteristics are included. This result should not be interpreted to mean that startup firms generally obtain cheaper credit than established businesses because the analysis observes only approved SBA 7(a) loans.

6. Robustness Checks

Table 3. Robustness of Extended-Model Startup Estimates

Specification	Log Gross Approval	Initial Interest Rate
Main model: lender clustering	-0.1478 (0.0512)	-0.1046 (0.0407)
Project-jurisdiction clustering	-0.1478 (0.0141)	-0.1046 (0.0217)
Strict business-age definition	-0.1779 (0.0521)	-0.0932 (0.0423)

Note. Standard errors in parentheses. The main and project-jurisdiction rows use the primary business-age definition; changing the clustering level changes estimated uncertainty, not the coefficient. The strict business-age definition retains the same startup category but restricts established businesses to “Existing, 5 or more years” and “Existing or more than 2 years old.” The strict log-loan coefficient corresponds to approximately -16.3%.

Two robustness exercises assess the sensitivity of the extended-model results. First, inference is recalculated using clustering by project jurisdiction rather than lender. The dataset contains 56 project-state/jurisdiction categories. The extended loan-amount coefficient remains -0.1478, with a jurisdiction-clustered standard error of 0.0141. The extended interest-rate coefficient remains -0.1046, with a jurisdiction-clustered standard error of 0.0217.

The coefficient estimates do not change because the regression specification and analytical observations are unchanged; only the estimated uncertainty changes. The substantially different standard errors across clustering approaches also demonstrate the importance of accounting for within-lender dependence in the primary inference.

Second, the analysis applies a stricter definition of established businesses. The startup definition remains unchanged, while the comparison group is limited to “Existing, 5 or more years” and “Existing or more than 2 years old.” This stricter classification produces 599,372 observations before model-specific missing-value exclusions.

In the extended loan model, the startup coefficient is -0.1779 (lender-clustered SE = 0.0521; $p < 0.001$), corresponding to approximately 16.3% lower gross approval amounts. For initial interest rates, the corresponding coefficient is -0.0932 percentage points (clustered SE = 0.0423; $p = 0.027$). The direction and approximate magnitude of the extended-model estimates therefore remain similar under the alternative business-age classification. This robustness does not establish causality.

7. Discussion

The results show that financing differences between startup and established borrowers within the SBA 7(a) program cannot be summarized by a single unconditional startup premium or penalty.

The most striking result concerns loan amount. Startups receive larger loans descriptively and retain an estimated 18.0% positive conditional difference after fiscal-year, jurisdiction, and industry controls. Once processing method, business type, and collateral status are added, however, the coefficient reverses and implies approximately 13.7% lower approval amounts.

This reversal suggests that observable differences in how startup and established-business loans are structured are closely related to the observed loan-size gap. Startups in the sample differ

substantially in collateral status, business type, industry composition, and program processing method. Conditioning on these characteristics changes the startup coefficient materially.

The analysis cannot determine why this reversal occurs. Some included characteristics may reflect lender screening or program structure, while others may be jointly related to borrower financing needs and startup status. Consequently, the extended specification is best interpreted as an alternative conditional comparison rather than a definitive causal model.

The interest-rate results provide a different pattern. Startup borrowers have slightly lower initial rates descriptively, and the negative association remains after increasingly detailed controls. The magnitude falls from approximately 0.205 percentage points in the baseline model to approximately 0.105 percentage points in the extended model.

At first glance, lower observed startup rates may appear inconsistent with a simple informational-opacity argument. Yet Cowling et al. (2026) show in a different institutional setting that firm-age pricing relationships can be non-monotonic: new firms within size classes can receive lower interest-rate offers than early-stage firms. That evidence does not identify the mechanism in the SBA data, but it cautions against treating lower observed startup rates as inherently contradictory to the broader entrepreneurial-finance literature.

Within SBA lending, several mechanisms could generate the observed patterns, including borrower selection, lender selection, program design, collateral, differences in loan characteristics, or unobserved borrower quality. The present data cannot distinguish among these mechanisms. The negative rate coefficient should therefore be treated as an empirical conditional association rather than evidence that lenders systematically price startup risk more favorably.

More broadly, the results are consistent with the view that entrepreneurial financing outcomes depend on both firm characteristics and the institutions and technologies through which financing is delivered, a perspective emphasized by Berger and Udell (2006).

8. Limitations

First, the data consist of approved SBA 7(a) loans. They do not contain a complete population of rejected applicants, firms that sought other forms of financing, or businesses that did not apply. The study therefore cannot estimate whether startups are more or less likely than established firms to obtain financing.

Second, the analysis is observational. Although the regressions account for many observable characteristics, startup status is not randomly assigned, and the models do not identify a causal effect of startup status on loan amount or interest rate.

Third, the SBA BusinessAge categories changed across reporting periods. The analysis addresses this problem by using an exact startup category available in both source files and excluding ambiguous categories. The stricter business-age robustness analysis further tests sensitivity, but measurement limitations remain.

Fourth, the administrative data used here do not incorporate all variables potentially relevant to underwriting and pricing. Borrower credit scores, detailed financial statements, profitability,

owner wealth, relationship history, and other measures of credit quality are not included in the estimated models. Omitted characteristics may therefore explain part of the startup coefficients.

Fifth, lender clustering relies on reported lender names because lender name is nearly complete, while alternative regulatory identifiers are unavailable for a nontrivial subset of observations. Changes in lender names, mergers, or naming conventions may introduce measurement noise into the clustering variable.

Sixth, FY2010-FY2025 spans substantial changes in monetary conditions, SBA policy, and the broader economy. Fiscal-year fixed effects account for common year-specific differences but do not capture every institutional change or heterogeneous response across borrowers.

Finally, the results are specific to SBA 7(a) lending and should not automatically be generalized to conventional bank lending, venture capital, private credit, or entrepreneurial financing outside the United States.

9. Conclusion

This study examines financing terms for startup and established-business borrowers using 681,992 approved SBA 7(a) loans from FY2010 through FY2025.

The descriptive evidence initially suggests that startups receive larger loans and slightly lower initial interest rates. Regression analysis, however, reveals a more nuanced pattern. After controlling for fiscal year, project jurisdiction, and industry, startup status is associated with approximately 18.0% higher gross approval amounts. After additional program and borrower characteristics are included, the association reverses to approximately 13.7% lower approval amounts.

For interest rates, startup status is associated with rates approximately 0.205 percentage points lower in the baseline specification and approximately 0.105 percentage points lower in the extended model. The direction of the extended estimates remains similar under alternative inference and a stricter business-age definition.

The central implication is therefore not that startup borrowers receive universally better or worse SBA financing terms. Instead, observed financing differences depend substantially on the characteristics of the loans, borrowers, industries, and program structures being compared.

Most importantly, these results characterize conditional associations among approved SBA 7(a) loans. They do not measure causal effects of startup status and do not establish whether startups have greater or lesser access to credit.

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